

My Family Background

My family is small, but our story is much greater than the number of people in it. My parents, Elman Saul Arana Flores and Alma Verónica Calderón Samayoa, raised my brother, Elman Ricardo Arana Calderón, my late sister, Bella Luz Arana Calderón, and me. Although only four of us are still alive today, I often think of my family as having five members from an eternal perspective. Like many families, we've faced financial hardships, disagreements, and moments of uncertainty. However, I believe that some of our deepest challenges have been less visible. They've had to do with learning to balance family responsibilities, personal identity, the expectations of others, and the desire to make everyone happy.

Both of my dads have worked hard to support our family. They've also made education and religion important parts of our lives. My dads always tried to give me the best education possible, both academically and spiritually. As a child, I sometimes took these opportunities for granted, but as I've grown older, I've realized that they were actually the result of years of sacrifice and hard work. I am deeply grateful for that.

At the same time, I've come to understand that my family has inherited some challenging patterns from previous generations. In particular, traditional ideas about the roles of men and women sometimes created expectations that were difficult to reconcile with modern family life. My mom has worked very hard to advance her career while also taking on responsibilities at home, and my dad has also had to deal with the expectations placed on him as the breadwinner. These experiences have taught me that family life requires more than simply fulfilling traditional roles. It requires communication, responsibility, sacrifice, and a willingness to change. My family has shown me that every generation inherits both blessings and challenges, and that part of the process of growing up involves learning what to hold on to and what patterns to change.

My Ancestral Heritage

Learning about my family's history has helped me understand that many of the experiences I have today did not begin with my generation. Some of my family's values, struggles, and opportunities were shaped by decisions made long before I was born. To learn more, I listened to stories from family members and compared those memories with what I already knew about our family's places of origin and relationships. Through this process, I also discovered that some details are difficult to confirm because family memories can change over time. Nevertheless, the stories I learned helped me see my family history as more than a collection of names and dates.

One of the most amusing stories in my family involves my maternal grandparents, my grandmother Alma's parents, and the Calderón family name. Before my grandmother married my grandfather, her father warned her to be careful because my grandfather's last name was Calderón. He believed that the Calderón family came from Sija, and he associated people from that region with theft because someone from Sija had once stolen horses from him. My grandmother defended my grandfather by explaining that he was from San Marcos. Technically, she was correct because my grandfather had been born there. However, as I learned more about my family's history, I discovered that my grandfather's parents were actually from Sija. They had moved to San Marcos because of the armed conflict in the region.

My grandfather's father wanted to protect his children and keep them away from the violence, so he moved his family to a safer place.

The story becomes even more interesting because something similar happened with my own parents. My mother, Alma Veronica Calderón Samayoa, had once been an outstanding student and even carried her school's flag. However, she eventually had a conflict with another student who was from Chocoma, Suchitepéquez. Because of that experience, she developed a negative opinion of the place. Years later, she married my father, Elman Saul Arana Flores, who was born in Quetzaltenango but whose parents came from Chocoma and whose family still has connections there. When my mother discovered this connection, she could only laugh because she had unknowingly repeated a version of my grandmother's story. These stories have taught me that prejudice can be passed from one generation to another, but humor and experience can also help us recognize and overcome it. I have learned that a person's last name or place of origin cannot define who that person truly is.

Another story that has deeply influenced my family is the story of my maternal grandmother and the education she was unable to receive. When she was young, she loved studying and had earned a scholarship to attend the Instituto Normal para Señoritas de Occidente in Quetzaltenango. However, her father did not allow her to accept the opportunity because the school was far from their home in Huehuetenango. She would have needed to move to another city, and her family did not permit her to do so. For my grandmother, losing that opportunity must have been painful, especially because she had earned it through her own effort.

Still, that was not the end of her story. My grandmother eventually went to live with an aunt, where she had the opportunity to work. Later, she came to Quetzaltenango with a cousin who had moved there to study. In Quetzaltenango, she eventually met my grandfather and began a new chapter of her life. Perhaps because she knew what it felt like to have an educational opportunity taken away, she became determined to give her daughters opportunities that she had not received. Although my grandfather believed that their daughters only needed a primary education, my grandmother continued supporting their studies as much as she could. Eventually, my aunts graduated as teachers and worked in education. My mother also studied teaching, but she decided to continue her education in medicine and eventually became a medical doctor and surgeon.

When I look at my own education today, I realize that my opportunities did not begin with me. They are part of a chain of sacrifices that stretches across generations. My grandmother could not follow the educational path she wanted, but she helped create a different path for her daughters. My mother continued that journey and, through her example, helped create opportunities for the next generation. In this way, my grandmother's dream did not disappear. It changed generations.

My family's history has also taught me that not every pattern we inherit should be repeated. Previous generations sometimes lived with traditional ideas about marriage and gender roles that encouraged women to endure difficult circumstances rather than defend their needs and encouraged men to measure their worth primarily by their ability to provide. I do not believe that these experiences make my ancestors bad people. Instead, I see them as part of the cultural circumstances in which they lived. However, I also believe that my generation has a responsibility to learn from those experiences. We can honor our ancestors while choosing healthier ways to communicate, share responsibilities, and build families.

My Legacy and Advice

If I could leave three pieces of advice for future generations of my family, the first would be to never allow prejudice to define another person. My family's stories about Sija and Chocola have shown me how easily one negative experience can become an unfair opinion about an entire community. We should take time to know people for their character and actions rather than judging them by their name, background, or place of origin.

Second, I would advise future generations to value the opportunities that others sacrificed to make possible. My grandmother lost an educational opportunity that she deeply wanted, but she later worked to make sure her daughters could study. Her story reminds me that education is not something I should take for granted. When I pursue my education, I am also honoring the sacrifices of those who came before me.

Finally, I would encourage my family to have the courage to break harmful patterns while preserving the good things we inherit. Honoring our ancestors does not mean repeating every mistake they made. We can appreciate their sacrifices, learn from their struggles, and build something better. My family has taught me that our legacy is not only what we receive from the past. It is also what we choose to change, improve, and pass forward. I hope future generations remember that even when a family carries sadness, mistakes, or unfinished dreams, those things do not have to be the end of the story. Sometimes, they can become the beginning of something better.